Week 4 Data, Power

After reading this week's chapters by D'Ignazio and Klein (2020) and Crawford (2021), I began to critically reflect on how data collection, classification hierarchies, and power operate on the social media platforms I use daily, particularly Reddit. Through my personal user experience, I have realised that platforms continuously gather large amounts of user data, often in invisible and unnoticeable ways. At times, I suspect platforms collect passive environmental information beyond explicit clicks and posts, including ambient audio and contextual conversations. For example, when I discuss Korean dramas with my classmates offline or in casual conversations, related content will immediately appear on my recommendation feed. This makes me feel that data collection extends far beyond my active online behaviour, creating potential privacy risks that users are rarely aware of.

What strikes me most is the powerless position of ordinary users. Almost all social platforms enforce standard data collection agreements that users must accept to access services. There is little to no option for users to opt out of excessive data collection or choose more privacy-friendly settings. Although users consent to these terms formally, few people fully understand how their data will be stored, analysed, extracted, or repurposed. As Crawford (2021) suggests, data is not neutrally collected but systematically extracted for commercial and algorithmic benefits, often at the expense of user privacy and transparency.

In daily use, I also observe how users unintentionally shape their own filter bubbles. While algorithmic recommendations make information retrieval more convenient and personalised, users gradually surrender part of their privacy and independent information access rights in exchange for comfortable, tailored content. In this sense, users voluntarily trade personal data and informational diversity for browsing convenience. I believe most users exist in a state of constant ambiguity and compromise: intuitively recognising that excessive data collection and closed information environments are problematic, yet continuing to accept these systems out of habit and necessity.

Furthermore, this week's discussion of hierarchies and binary classification strongly resonates with my experience on Reddit. Platforms establish fixed classification systems, binary tags, and algorithmic hierarchies purely for their own data-processing efficiency. All user-generated content and personal behavioural data must fit into the platform's predefined categories. Users can only adapt to these rigid classification rules and fill information according to the platform's logic, rather than defining their own categorisation or expression methods. It is nearly impossible for individual users to challenge, change, or restructure the platform's existing data hierarchy.

Combined with D'Ignazio and Klein's (2020) argument that "what gets counted counts", I recognise that platform classification is never neutral. The fixed hierarchies

simplify diverse, ambiguous human behaviour into calculable binary data, ignoring complexity while concentrating power in the hands of platform corporations. Ultimately, users not only lose control over their personal data but also unconsciously allow platforms to shape their information worldview, preference boundaries, and online identities.